buoy (bɔɪ, bwɔɪ), *v.* Also 7 boy, bouy. [In senses 1–3 app. adapted from some foreign source: cf. Sp. *boyar* to float (f. *boya* BUOY sb.), and see BUOYANT; in sense 4 from the sb.]

†**1.** *intr.* To rise to, or float on, the surface of a liquid; to rise, swell (as the sea). *Obs.*

1605 SHAKS. *Lear* III. vii. 60 The Sea, with such a storme ..would haue buoy'd vp And quench'd the Stelled fires. **1625** PURCHAS *Pilgrimes* II. 1617 Our Wine wee saued which boyed to the shoare. **1674** N. FAIRFAX *Bulk & Selv.* 73 Which will not allow an heavy body left to itself within a flowsom one that is lighter, to buoy up.

†**b.** *fig. Obs.*

1709 POPE *Ess. Crit.* 463 Rising merit will buoy up at last. **1716–8** —— in *Lady M. W. Montague's Lett.* I. viii. 24 Folly ..will buoy up..in spite of all our art to keep it down. **1742** YOUNG *Nt. Th.* VI. 251 When the great Soul buoys up to this high Point.

2. *trans.* To keep from sinking (in a fluid), to keep afloat; *transf.* to keep up, support, sustain. (Usually with *up.*)

1651 T. BARKER *Art Angling* (1653) 8 The menow may swim..being boyed up with a Cork or Quill. **1774** BURKE *Corr.* (1844) I. 490 It is as hard to sink a cork, as to buoy up a lump of lead. **1782** A. MONRO *Compar. Anat.* (ed. 3) 3 The bat and flying squirrel..have wings to buoy themselves up in the air. **1809** W. IRVING *Knickerb.* II. v. (1849) 113 Thus buoyed up, he floated on the waves.

b. To raise to the surface of a liquid; to bring afloat (e.g. a sunken ship).

1616 BEAUM. & FL. *Cust. Country* I. i, I will descend to thee, And buoy thee up. **1667** *Lond. Gaz.* No. 196/3 She sunk, with a Lighter..Great care is taking to Buoy them up with all the speed that may be. **1756** C. LUCAS *Ess. Waters* III. 297 They..buoy up some particles of the iron & carry it to the surface.

3. *fig.* To keep up, keep from sinking, support, sustain, (persons, courage, hope, heart, spirits, etc.). (Usually with *up.*)

1645 in Rushw. *Hist. Coll.* IV. I. 136 Lord Byron buoy'd up with continual hopes. **1681** DRYDEN *Abs. & Achit.* 821 Brave to buoy the State. *a* **1797** H. WALPOLE *Mem. Geo. III,* (1845) I. ix. 135 France had been buoyed up by the ambition ..of Spain. **1836** MARRYAT *Japhet* xliii, The hopes which had been..buoying me up.

b. To raise, lift, cause to rise (the heart, spirits, etc.). (Usually with *up.*)

1652 J. WADSWORTH tr. *Sandoval's Civ. Wars Spain* 181 They ought to..boüy them up out of that gulf of miserie whereinto they were plunged. **1662** FULLER *Worthies* I. 262 Hearts sunk down are not to be boyed up. *a* **1796** BURKE *Regic. Peace* i. Wks. VIII. 86 Buoyed up to the highest point of practical vigour. *a* **1850** ROSSETTI *Dante & Circ.* I. (1874) 185 The spirits of thy life depart Daily to heaven with her —they so are buoy'd With their desire.

4. To furnish or mark with a buoy or buoys; to mark as with a buoy (rarely with *out*).

1596 RALEIGH *Discov. Guiana* 36 Which shold [= shoal] John Douglas boyed and bekonned for them before. **1707** *Lond. Gaz.* No. 4350/3 They have..lately buoy'd a new Chanel..with 3 Black Buoys. **1710** in Picton *L'pool Munic. Rec.* (1886) II. 49 The buoying out of Formby Channell. **1772–84** COOK *Voy.* (1790) I. 215 The captain sounded and buoyed the bar. **1883** DK. ARGYLL *Sp. Ho. Lords* 19 July, Rocks on the [Scotch] west coast are not sufficiently buoyed and beaconed.

buoyage ('bɔɪɪdʒ, bwɔɪ-). [f. BUOY *v.* and *sb.* + -AGE.] The providing of (or with) buoys; buoys collectively, a series of buoys which mark out a channel.

1855 in OGILVIE Suppl. **1858** *Merc. Mar. Mag.* V. 29 Buoyage of the River Tees. **1863** *Standard* 5 Sept. 3/1 Charged equally by law with the buoyage, beaconage, and